

GOVERNMENT HACK · TROOPTOTEACHER TECHNOLOGIES

# Foundations of Constitutional Government

United States Government & Civics (GC) · Unit 7 · GC.28–GC.30

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*“How does Tennessee govern itself at the state and local levels — and how do you take part?”*

Grades 9–12 · Suggested 12–14 days · Supplemental under TCA § 49-6-2202(a)(3)

**Essential Question: How does Tennessee govern itself at the state and local levels — and how do you take part?**

**GC.28**

Tennessee's Three Branches

**GC.29**

Local Government in Tennessee

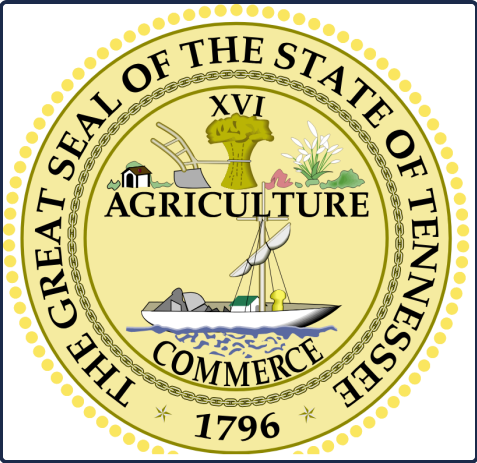
**GC.30**

Identify Your Current Officials

# Tennessee's Three Branches

**Learning target:** I can identify the functions of the departments and agencies of Tennessee's executive, legislative, and judicial branches.

PRIMARY SOURCE



The Great Seal of the State of Tennessee (statehood 1796) — the emblem of the state government whose three branches this standard examines.

*“The powers of the Government shall be divided into three distinct departments: Legislative, Executive, and Judicial.”*  
— Constitution of Tennessee, Tennessee Constitution, Article II, Section 1 (1870)

The Great Seal of the State of Tennessee · State of Tennessee (1802 design) · Wikimedia Commons

KEY VOCABULARY

**Grand Divisions** /grand dih-VIZH-unz/  
**Grandes Divisiones**

The three legal regions of Tennessee — East, Middle, and West — recognized in state law and marked by the three stars on the state flag; the state balances offices and representation across all three.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING · DOK 2

**In Tennessee's trial-court system, which court is a court of equity, presided over by a Chancellor?**

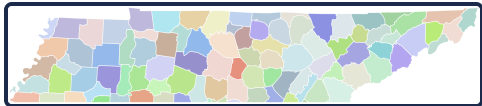
- A Criminal Court
- B ✓ Chancery Court**
- C Circuit Court
- D The U.S. District Court

★ **TENNESSEE** This entire standard is Tennessee. The three stars on the state flag stand for the three Grand Divisions — East, Middle, and West — and Tennessee law spreads offices and representation across all three. The state's part-time citizen-legislature and its distinctive 'Tennessee Plan' for choosing appellate judges are features of Tennessee's own constitution and law (GC.28).

# Local Government in Tennessee

**Learning target:** I can explain the differences among county, city, and metropolitan governments in Tennessee and how they relate legally, fiscally, and operationally to the state.

## PRIMARY SOURCE



Tennessee's ninety-five counties — the county layer of local government that covers every part of the state. Find your own county on the map.

*“The qualified voters of each county shall elect for terms of four years a legislative body, a county executive, a Sheriff, a Trustee, a Register, a County Clerk and an Assessor of Property.”* — Constitution of Tennessee, Tennessee Constitution, Article VII, Section 1 (1978)

Tennessee County Map (all 95 counties) · U.S. Census Bureau (derivative) (n.d.) · Wikimedia Commons

## KEY VOCABULARY

### Unitary Government /YOO-nih-tair-ee/

#### gobierno unitario

A system in which a central government — here, the state — holds the primary authority and creates the local governments beneath it, which exercise only the powers the state grants. Tennessee is a unitary state.

## CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING · DOK 2

**Tennessee is a unitary state. What does that mean for your county and city governments?**

- A They are completely independent of the state
- B They report directly to the federal government
- C ✓ They are created by the state and hold only the powers the state grants them**
- D They may set aside state law within their own borders

★ **TENNESSEE** Tennessee's local map is its own: ninety-five counties, hundreds of cities, and a constitution that lets voters merge a city and its county into a single consolidated 'metropolitan' government — a structural model Tennessee helped pioneer. Study your own county and city to see which of these Tennessee structures governs your daily life (GC.29).

**UDL 3.0 (CAST):** read-aloud on request · key terms glossed EN/ES · respond in writing, speech, or a labeled diagram · large-print & screen-reader friendly.

**MTSS:** Tier 1 core lesson for all · Tier 2 small-group reteach of this standard (Cornell cues + graphic organizer), then re-check · Tier 3 intensive 1:1 with concrete → representational → abstract scaffolding, progress-monitored to the same standard.

# Identify Your Current Officials

**Learning target:** I can identify the current governor of Tennessee and the state legislators who represent me, using official sources.

## PRIMARY SOURCE



The Tennessee state flag: its three stars stand for the three Grand Divisions — East, Middle, and West.

*“The Supreme Executive power of this State shall be vested in a Governor.”* — Constitution of Tennessee, Tennessee Constitution, Article III, Section 1 (1870)

## HOOK

*Right now, a governor in Nashville and two legislators — one senator, one representative — make decisions for the exact spot where you live. Do you know their names? By the end of this lesson, you will have looked them up yourself.*

## KEY VOCABULARY

**Governor** /GUV-ur-ner/

**gobernador(a)**

Tennessee's chief executive, elected statewide to a four-year term, who carries out state law, proposes the state budget, and

## CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING · DOK 1

**To find out who currently represents you in the Tennessee General Assembly, the best source is —**

- A** ✓ the official 'Find My Legislator' tool on the Tennessee General Assembly site ([capitol.tn.gov](http://capitol.tn.gov))
- B** a rumor you saw on social media
- C** a textbook printed several years ago
- D** a friend's best guess

**Answer: A.** DOK 1: Officeholders change with each election, so

★ **TENNESSEE** There is no more Tennessee-specific civic act than naming the people who govern you: your governor in Nashville and the senator and representative elected from your own district. This standard asks you to find and record them from official Tennessee sources — a skill you will use in every election (GC.30).

**UDL 3.0 (CAST):** read-aloud on request · key terms glossed EN/ES · respond in writing, speech, or a labeled diagram · large-print & screen-reader friendly.

**MTSS:** Tier 1 core lesson for all · Tier 2 small-group reteach of this standard (Cornell cues + graphic organizer), then re-check · Tier 3 intensive 1:1 with concrete → representational → abstract scaffolding, progress-monitored to the same standard.

# Whose Government? Perspectives on Power in Tennessee

## Separation of Powers, State Level

Tennessee splits authority into three departments — legislative, executive, and judicial — the same design as the national government, applied to the state (GC.28).

## Balancing the Grand Divisions

East, Middle, and West Tennessee each carry distinct histories and interests; the state deliberately balances offices and representation across all three (GC.28).

## A Unitary State, Layered Locally

Authority flows from the state down to counties, cities, and consolidated metropolitan governments — each one created by, and answerable to, the state (GC.29).

## Representation and Civic Action

Government reaches all the way down to your own district and your own officials — and this unit asks you to identify them, contact them, and take part (GC.30).

# Our Signature Move



This whole unit is the Tennessee Connection. Foundations traced government in the abstract; here it becomes concrete and local — the Capitol in Nashville, the three Grand Divisions marked by the three stars on the state flag, the ninety-five counties on the state map, and the specific legislators elected from your own district. Tennessee is not an example in this unit; Tennessee is the subject (GC.28–GC.30).

# Predict • Play • Spiral

## Predict First — open the unit

Predict first: Which level of government — your city, your county, or the state — do you think has the biggest effect on your daily life? Write your gut answer now; you'll test it against how Tennessee actually divides and shares power.

## Warm-Up Play — Who Governs? / Which Court?

4-minute game (GC.28–GC.29). Read a one-line scenario — a felony trial, a property-line dispute, a new city zoning rule, a statewide budget — and call which trial court (Circuit, Chancery, or Criminal) or which level of government (city, county, or state) handles it. Students feel how Tennessee's three branches and its layers of local government split the work.

## Spiral — retrieve & connect

### GC.28 → Unit 1 (Foundations — separation of powers)

Tennessee's three departments mirror the federal separation of powers you met in Foundations — same design, applied at the state level.

### GC.29 → Unit 1/2 (federalism)

Federalism divides power between the nation and the states; this unit goes one layer deeper — how a state shares power with its counties and cities.

### GC.30 → Unit 3 (GC.14, your members of Congress)

In Unit 3 you identified your U.S. senators and representative; now identify who represents you in Nashville — your state senator and state representative.

## Local Government Forum

- Name the level (city / county / state) and the branch before you argue.
- Use your own county or district as a real, concrete example.
- Separate 'how it works now' from 'what you would change.'
- One voice at a time; make room for the quiet voice.



# Revisit the Essential Question

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“How does Tennessee govern itself at the state and local levels — and how do you take part?”

Students now have the sources, vocabulary, and reasoning to answer it — in a CER paragraph or the unit DBQ.

GC.28 · GC.29 · GC.30